

Honda City (licence plate 111), she sees its spaceship roof every day.

Nehwal is 5ft 6½ inches, neither physically distinctive nor statuesque. A badminton player's footwork can be set to Vivaldi but Nehwal walks stumpily, as if there is glue on her shoes. Her hair is pulled back, disciplined by numerous clips, her face scrubbed clean, it's perfect oval and the mole on her cheek indistinct under a prominent impression of purpose.

When she gets onto court, nothing remains indistinct. She turns into a synthesis of energy, movement and craft. For the first 45 minutes, she does not use her smash. As a 14-year-old, she used the smash as a shot of choice, but her stroke-play and game have expanded since. This particular drill works her movement, exercises shot options and strengthens her defence. She will have spent six weeks at home before the Worlds, training through a fitness and on-court schedule drawn up on January 28.



VEGETARIAN SAINA STARTED

Baseline to No. 6

SAINA NEHWAL

Born: March 17, 1990, Hissar; Height: 5ft 6½ inches
Weight: 62 kg; Current World Ranking: 6

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| ■ Winner, Junior Czech Open, 2003 | ■ Bronze medallist, Commonwealth Games, 2006 (mixed team event) | Open, 2008 |
| ■ Winner, National Junior Championships, 2004 & 2005 | ■ Winner, Philippines Open, 2006 (first Indian woman to win a four-star tournament) | ■ Gold medallist, Commonwealth Youth Games, 2008 |
| ■ Silver medallist, Commonwealth Youth Games, Bendigo, Australia, 2004 | ■ Winner, Asian Satellite Badminton Tournament, 2006, Mumbai | ■ Winner, World Junior Badminton Championships, 2008 |
| ■ Winner, Asian Satellite Badminton Tournament, Delhi, 2005 | ■ Winner, National Senior Championships, 2007 | ■ Quarter-finalist, Beijing Olympics, 2008 |
| ■ Finalist, World Junior Badminton Championships, 2006, Incheon, Korea | ■ Gold medallist, National Games of India, 2007 | ■ Quarter-finalist, Singapore Open Super Series Grand Prix, 2009 |
| | ■ Winner, Indian International Challenge, 2007 | ■ Winner, Indonesian Open Super Series Grand Prix, 2009 |
| | ■ Winner, Yonex Chinese Taipei | |

She hits with Gopichand and two other men; their shots echo in the high archway of the hall like colliding high-tension wires. Twice in the session her pulse is checked by physio Kiran Challagundla, who explains later that she needs to maintain her threshold heart rate of 180-190 beats per minute (bpm) for half an hour. So when it shoots to 160 bpm during matches she is in, as Gopichand sees it, a "comfort zone", her mind uncluttered by physical strain.

Endurance is the foundation of her sport: players cover nearly six km in a 75-minute singles match. (In a tennis match lasting three times longer a player covers around three km). In no other a sport is there such a diversity of movement: badminton players leap off the ground, smash, run cross-court, bend to pick up a drop in less time than it takes to read this sentence. They raise and lower the arm repeatedly, causing their hearts to work harder pumping blood upward. Basketballers go vertical to horizontal and tennis players switch from power to touch but never so quickly, nor so often. Badminton is the marriage of muscle, mind and thoroughbred lungs.

Nehwal is candid, "I don't have very good skill in my strokes, but I try to pick up all the shuttles." (Not surprisingly Rafael Nadal is a hero but when she caught sight of him in the Olympic dining hall she was too shy to go up and say hello.) Improved fitness has translated into better defence, retrieval and net play which have led to victories over the world's top-ranked Chinese women.

The formidable Chinese come off a conveyer-